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Grade	1	Word Count	174
Lexile	440L	Multi-level	G N R
Learning A–Z	level G		

Refer to the Focus Question on page 2 of this title to guide discussion and support additional learning connected to the text.

Most people don't think much about the small and slimy earthworm, but worms actually have a big role in our environment. **Wiggly Worms** teaches students about a worm's body and behaviors, how it helps plants and other animals, and its place in the food chain.

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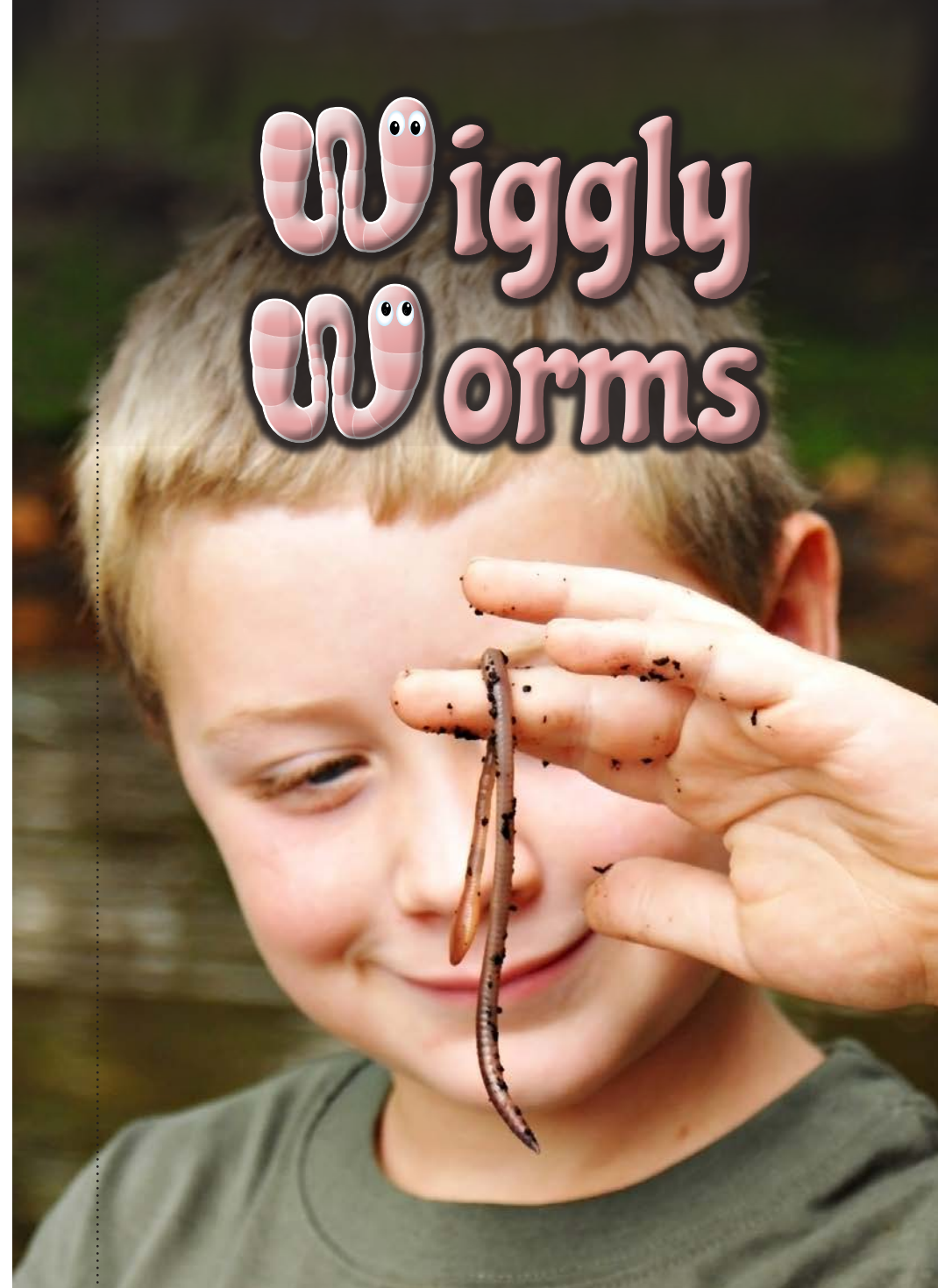
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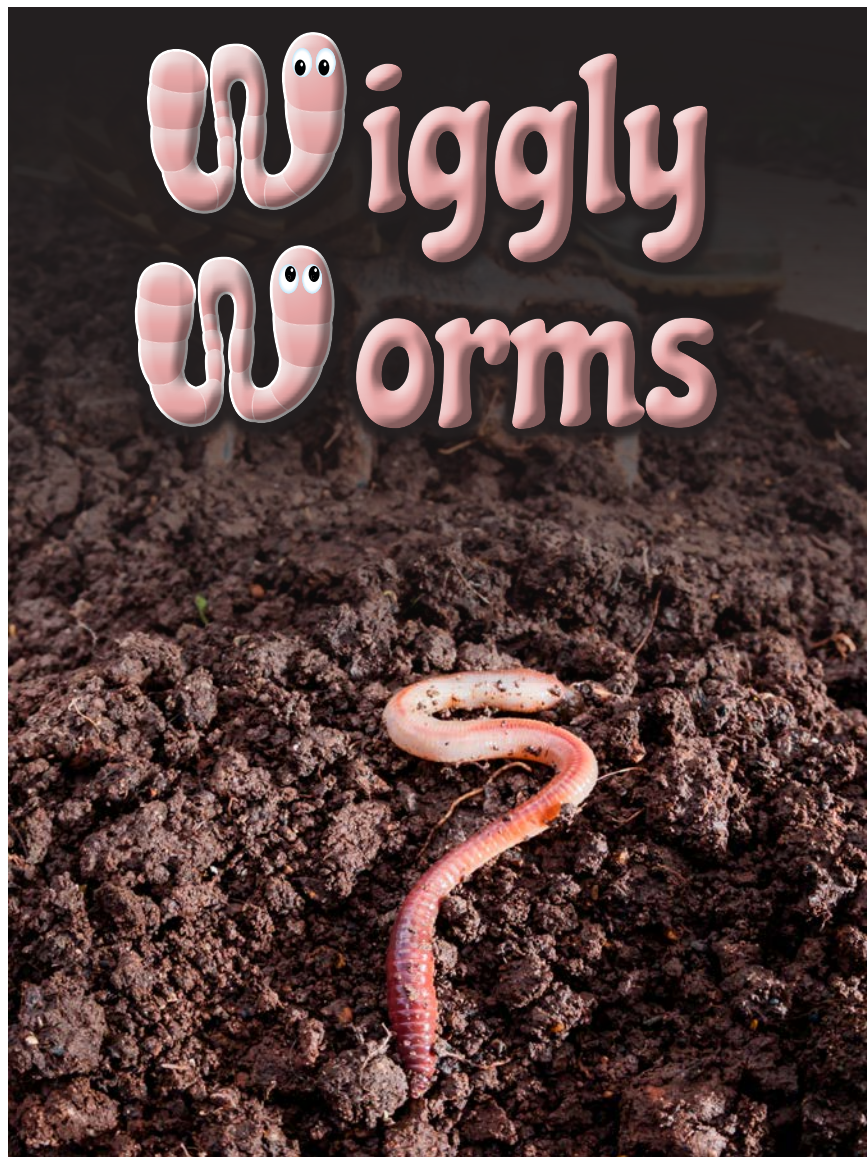
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Wiggly Worms



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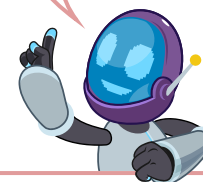
Written by Cheryl Reifsnyder

Above: An earthworm crawls away after being dug out of the ground by a gardener.

Page 3: A worm sticks its head out of its tunnel near some mushrooms.

Focus Question

Why are earthworms so important?



Words to Know

cocoon

soil

mate

tunnels

slimy

waste



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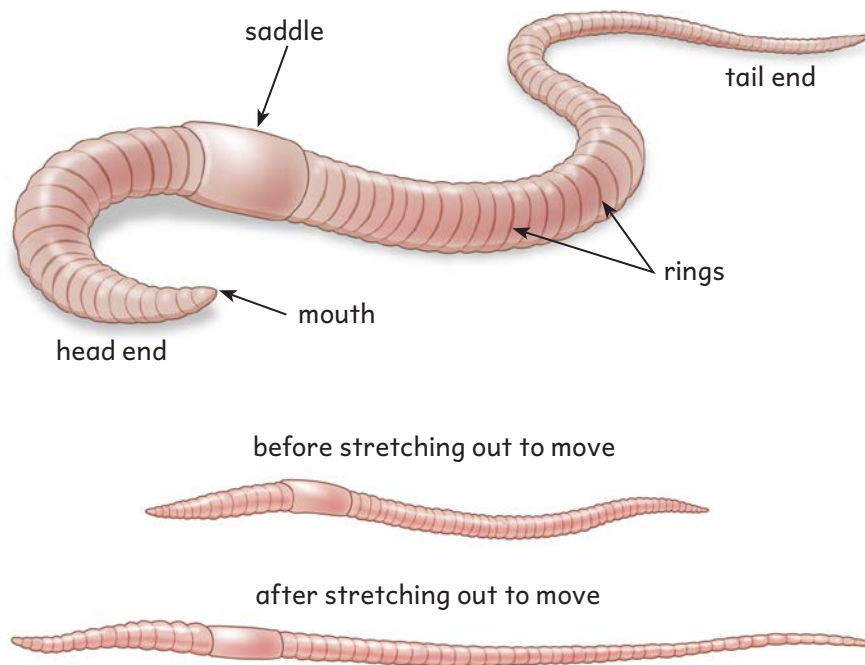
Small Animals, Big Changes

Do you know about
earthworms?

These small animals change
the **soil** in big ways.

Earthworm Bodies

The body of an earthworm is made up of many parts. Each part is shaped like a ring. Each part can bend and stretch. Earthworms move by stretching and pulling their bodies.



Slimy Worms!

Earthworms are **slimy**.

The slime helps keep earthworms cool and wet. It also helps earthworms slide through soil.

After worms **mate**, a ball of slime forms.

The slime dries into a **cocoon**. Baby worms come out of the cocoon.



A bird has to work to pull a strong worm out of its hole.

Earthworm Behavior

Earthworms build long **tunnels** underground.

The tunnels keep worms away from heat and sunlight.

They also help earthworms hide from hungry animals.



A worm pulls a leaf into its hole.

Earthworms come out at night to look for food.

Some people call them night crawlers.

Earthworms eat dead leaves and plants.



Earthworm tunnels help water and air reach plant roots.

Earthworms Are Good for the Soil

Farmers love earthworms!
Earthworms make space
in the soil.

The space helps plants get
what they need to grow.
Earthworm **waste** helps plants
grow big and strong.



A mole (top left), a shrew (top right), and a toad (bottom)
all make meals of worms.

Wanted: Earthworms!

Many animals love to eat
earthworms.



An earthworm pokes its head out of its hole.

Earthworms are small, but
they have a big job.
Earthworms help plants grow!

Glossary

cocoon (*n.*) page 6

a covering that protects something

mate (*v.*) page 6

to come together to reproduce,
or make babies

slimy (*adj.*) page 6

covered by or feeling like
something wet and slippery

soil (*n.*) page 4

the top layer of the ground in
which plants grow; dirt

tunnels (*n.*) page 7

underground passages

waste (*n.*) page 9

solid matter passed out of the body
of an animal